

**SOUTHERN
STORY:
Chiranjeevi
hopes to
make a mark
in the assem-
bly elections
due next year**

Telangana state. "If Chiranjeevi is really sincere about Telangana, he should come out openly in support of a separate state. But if he tries to fool the people by saying he would take an appropriate decision at an appropriate time, the public also would teach him an appropriate lesson at an appropriate time," she warns. Singing a similar tune is D.K. Roja, Chiranjeevi's heroine in three films and now the president of the Telugu Mahila—the women's wing of the Telugu Desam Party (TDP). "How can one expect a man, who has done nothing for the welfare of the film industry workers, to work for the welfare of the people of the state," wonders Roja, adding that Chiranjeevi is "a softie who doesn't have the mindset to be in politics". She also accuses him of taking credit for the blood donated by his fans and some funds he put in to avoid paying tax in the blood and eye banks built on the land given by TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu.

Miffed at the digs taken at their favourite star, some die-hard fans of the Telugu 'megastar' have taken to conducting mock 'exorcising rituals'

have much time to firm up the PRP policies on basic as well as contentious issues. This, in turn, has tongues wagging about the actor being naïve. But those who know him vouch that Chiranjeevi is a meticulous planner who loathes taking risks. It's a strategy that has served him well as an actor and now his admirers hope it will pay off as he sets out on his most ambitious venture—to become Andhra Pradesh's next chief minister.

For decades now, the political and the film fraternities have been indelibly linked in all southern states barring Kerala where the lines are clearly demarcated. But it is in Tamil Nadu where the links are the strongest, where nearly 60 years ago, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) offered a heady mix of politics and cinema. The party founder, C.N. Annadurai, and his lieutenant, M. Karunanidhi, both celebrated scriptwriters, used the storyline and powerful dialogues to espouse the cause of rationalism, social reforms and the party's ideals. M.G. Ramachandran, a khadi-clad, rudraksha-wearing Congressman, struggling to make it in



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against both Vijayashanti and Roja. Garlands made of sliced pumpkins and lemons were placed on their photographs recently. Even then they have been luckier than Chiranjeevi's longstanding rivals, actors Rajasekhar and his wife Jeevita, who were warned of wrath by his supporters for having doubted his ability to comprehend and hence becoming a part of the Andhra Pradesh politics some months back. Telugu filmdom is divided on Chiranjeevi's foray into politics. Suhasini, wife of director Mani Ratnam and a celebrated actor in the southern film industry, has welcomed his arrival on the political stage while Radhika, who paired with the actor in 18 films, has also endorsed Chiranjeevi's plans.

After launching and naming his party at a massive convention in the temple town of Tirupathi on August 26, Chiranjeevi had announced that the basic tenets of his party were greater equity and social justice. The assembly elections in Andhra Pradesh are due next year and the actor does not

films, smelt the opportunity and joined the DMK and used his films, which were mostly about the struggles of the poor, to spread the message of the party.

His roaring film career and philanthropy made him popular. The role he took in politics brought him in direct contact with his fans association. This came in handy when he was suspended from the DMK in October 1972 and went on to form the Anna DMK, now renamed the AIDMK. Five years later, MGR became chief minister, a post that he occupied till December 1987. As the Anna DMK founder, MGR anointed Jayalalithaa, his leading lady in scores of Tamil blockbusters, as his successor and in 1991, she became the state's second actor-turned-chief minister, although efforts were made to prop up MGR's widow, Janaki, as his political successor.

On the other hand, egged on by rebel Congress leaders, NTR launched the TDP in July 1982 and in less than nine months became the chief minister. That was the first time the Congress was dislodged from power in the state which had remained its



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